ALCHEMY of BREATH

THE BRAND

INTRODUCTION

A collective consciousness.

Alchemy of Breath has been on a journey of growth, both literally and figuratively. We've come a long way since that five-person session in Bali where it all began.

As our company grows and our community flourishes, having a clearly defined brand will empower everyone on our team to think as one, to embody our purpose and mission, and to feel confident making decisions in the interests of our shared future. Think of it as a collective consciousness: a set of beliefs, ideas and attitudes we're united by, both internally and externally.

Our brand is a truly collaborative effort, made up of insights from our team and community. It's about more than fonts and colours (though you'll find those here, too). It's a lens through which we see the world. A framework for decisions large and small – from the way we design an email, to the courses we launch in the future.

This brand guide is for everyone who works for or with Alchemy of Breath. If you're ever in doubt, we hope it can help light the way.

ALCHEMY OF BREATH

Finding meaning in our name.

Alchemy of Breath describes the seemingly magical process of transformation breathwork brings about.

It reminds us of the mysterious power in a process as humble as breathing. The miracle of an inhale. The marvel of an exhale.

With each breath, everything is possible.

(Some of our team and community might know us as ‘AoB’ – and that’s fine, too. But we always write our name in full in our marketing and communications.)

OUR STORY
We're on The Quest.

There are seven story archetypes, also known as the ‘seven basic plots’. The theory is that every story – whether in literature, film or marketing – fits one of these plots.

Alchemy of Breath’s story is The Quest.

Similar to the hero’s journey, the quest is about progression. A protagonist (who in this case is Anthony, but could also represent any member of our community) travels in search of a priceless treasure. They must overcome obstacles or challenges to progress on their journey.

Since our ideal customer is on ‘The Quest’, it means we're in it for the long haul. Alchemy of Breath must provide a long-lasting tool or ongoing companionship that withstands the test of time and overcomes any odds our customers face, however daunting they might be.

Anthony had it all. He was wealthy and successful. Brought up in a middle-class family and educated in private school, he'd built a career in architecture and a beautiful home for his family. He went on holidays several times a year and bought mostly anything he wanted.

He was exhausted. Overwhelmed. Adrift.

Finally, in his forties, Anthony broke free. He went on a journey of discovery – first to India and then Bali – to meditate and reunite with himself. After four decades on this planet, he found the courage to face his feelings.

It was simpler than he thought. As simple as breathing.

In a shady room in Ubud, he gathered a tiny group of people. People like him, looking for a different way to be, to connect, to live. They breathed together.

Inhale. Exhale.

Soon three people became fifty, and the group grew bigger still. They did the simplest thing – the most frequently used bodily function we have. In breathing, they discovered how to be who they are. Together, they created a place they could feel safe. Space to heal.

In this seemingly magical process of transformation, Alchemy of Breath was born.

OUR PURPOSE, MISSION & VISION

The essence of who we are.

Our purpose, mission and vision are the foundation upon which our brand is built. If you reduce it all down, this is what’s left. It might not cover everything we believe or do, but it does describe the essence of who we are.

OUR PURPOSE

Our core belief. Our driving force. Our 'why'.

We believe changing our world starts from within.

OUR MISSION

How we serve. Putting our purpose into practice.

We inspire you to transform your life and empower others with breathwork.

OUR VISION

What we strive for. What success looks like.

We envision a world where everyone is empowered by breathwork.

WE'RE A VISIONARY BRAND

Understanding our archetype.

Of the 12 universal brand archetypes, Alchemy of Breath is the Visionary – also known as the Healer.

That’s not to say we have to fit a specific idea of what a Visionary brand is. But understanding the strengths and weaknesses typical of our archetype can make us more self-aware and empowered to make better choices – much like knowing ourselves can, too.

Brand promise: Transformation

Goal: We want to use our knowledge of how the breath works to change our customers' lives for the better. We aim to create a practice that's special and informative, teaching by example or invitation rather than instruction to empower ourselves and others.

Strategy: We create a unique vision and live by it.

Attributes: We're intelligent, idea-driven and ever curious, thriving on vision and intuition. As is typical of visionary brands, Alchemy of Breath has a spiritual or psychological element in that we want to expand our customers' collective consciousness. We value magical moments and strive to make things exciting. We crave adventure and inspire people to break free from the ordinary, go further and try new things.

Fears: We worry about unintended negative consequences of our exploration. As with many visionary brands, the worst thing that could happen to Alchemy of Breath would be for us to be seen as hollow in our aims. We fear becoming apathetic, as this would mean not living by our vision. We don't wish to be seen as a hero and must avoid illusions of grandeur.

At best: Charismatic, visionary, healing, driven

At worst: Dishonest, manipulative, distant, disconnected

Motivations: We want to understand the universe and our position in the world. We're interested in new ways and finding solutions not yet imagined.

Challenges: We have many different ideas and aspirations, which can make it hard to stay committed to one vision. Sometimes we might struggle because we expect more than is possible.

How we serve: Visionaries have access to secret information, which we impart to our customers to give them value, solve their problems, and make their wishes come true. We empower our customers to rise above the typical crowd and serve as a catalyst for change, turning problems into opportunities.

Who we serve: The visionary customer is motivated both by the desire for personal transformation and to be a change agent in the world around them. They are open to change and evolution. They have a sense of urgency to be a part of the 'magic'. They are often in a position of leadership (or might be in the future) and need to feel we can help them grow wiser and influence people. Visionary customers are driven by imaginative, inspiring advertising.

How we communicate: Compelling and charismatic, we promote wonder and a promise for change or transformation. Despite our strong community, we focus on individuality and encourage our customers to trust their own instincts. We inspire curiosity, confidence and fascination with the possibilities and promise our brand has to offer, which creates a strong, loyal following.

OUR VALUES

Bringing us into alignment.

Our values are shared by everyone in our community – from our internal team, to our students and graduates, to everyone who breathes with us across the world. They are a framework for the way we operate. The ‘how’ to our ‘why’.

Be open.

Can you be present, with love? Observe judgment, stay curious, and learn about yourself through others. Know that we're all humans with unique experiences.

Be courageous.

What's your next best choice? Don't be afraid to feel your feelings, show vulnerability, and be who you are. It is by making fresh choices you can create the life you want.

You are safe.

Can you honor our responsibility to one another? Have confidence in your body and own your process. Know that you are where you need to be.

OUR CODE OF CONDUCT

Living by our values.

Our code of conduct is how we put our values to work. It’s a set of commitments for how we run our business and nurture our community in a way that’s true to who we are and what we believe.

We commit to...
Diverse community.

Point made by the team that the first step here is to outline what we mean by a diverse community – this would be part of the D&I strategy that will hopefully result from this brand work.

We believe the breath belongs to everyone, so we encourage diversity and inclusion in the following ways:

- **Community breathwork sessions** – our way of giving back to our community, our regular, free online sessions are available to anyone, anywhere in the world (as many times as you like)
- **Scholarship programme** – each year we offer XX free spaces on our breathwork facilitator training course for underrepresented people
- **Diverse representation** – we strive to make our facilitator and speaker line-up diverse in terms of age, ability, gender, race and sexual orientation
- **Community outreach** – we teach free classes in local dialect for members of our local communities in the regions where our global team are based
- **Unconscious bias training** – for our team and in our facilitator training syllabus

We commit to...
Reflective listening.

We want to create a space where everyone can listen and help one another/share their feelings and experiences, so we:

- **Train our facilitators and graduates** to acknowledge shares without judgement or comparison
- **Encourage our community** to communicate with awareness, compassion and respect
- **Focusing on self-love in our training** – we believe that by learning to love parts of ourselves we might previously have been ashamed of, we can become more compassionate humans; so we dedicate time and energy to this never-ending journey in order to nurture well-rounded facilitators

We commit to...
Community co-creation.

Alchemy of Breath is your community – you co-create our events by being there and without you, we wouldn't be where we are today. We invite you to step up and take ownership of the two-way relationship we share. Together, we continue to learn and grow through:

- **Alchemy Insights** – a monthly open-door online meeting where our community has the opportunity to share their feedback and ideas
- **Implementing feedback** – we're constantly reviewing our processes and content in response to suggestions from our community
- **Graduate mentoring** – because we want to create ongoing, two-way relationships and a structure of support, all Alchemy of Breath graduates have the opportunity to mentor new students
- **Ongoing graduate education** – your breathwork education doesn't end with the teacher training course: join us for regular graduate sessions, where we share the latest thinking and continually pursue excellence

We commit to...
Unique expression.

Every manifestation of Alchemy of Breath is individual – it’s not about trimming people into the same shape or mold. We foster individuality, promote authenticity and encourage unique expression by:

- **Infusing unique talents** – our facilitators make their offerings unique by infusing their own talents and learnings
- **Transforming challenges into gifts** – our training empowers you to transform your greatest challenge into a strength you can choose to share with the world
- **Non-dogmatic training** – we don't lay down principles as undeniably true and we won't impose our own beliefs on you, because we believe in giving room for personal interpretation

We commit to...
Professional practice.

We aim for excellence, upholding industry best practice and the highest ethical standards, because we aim to create a benchmark for the breathwork industry. We do this in the following ways:

- **Global accreditation** – our breathwork facilitator training is one of the only available courses accredited by the Global Professional Breathwork Alliance and the Australian Breathwork Association.
- **Code of Ethics** – we've outlined the ways we make sure our practice is ethical and made this document available publicly, because we want to be accountable for the work that we do. The Ethical Standards are a set of guidelines we expect all our students and graduates to abide by.
- **Training quality facilitators** – our intensive breathwork facilitator training takes 400 hours over nine months, because we believe that’s what it takes to hold others safely and responsibly. We also offer the opportunity to take the whole course again for free as a mentor.
- **Transparency around contraindications** – everyone can do breathwork, but some techniques are unsuitable for people with certain physical and mental conditions. We make sure everyone knows that and offer alternative advice or options.
- **Being experts** – the majority of our team has undergone our breathwork facilitator training, and we’re dedicated to continuously educating ourselves. So you can be confident that wherever you communicate with us – from our free community sessions, to our social media channels – you’ll be dealing with an expert.

We commit to...
Inclusive practice.

Breathing is universal. We believe in empowerment, so we strive to make everyone feel confident and comfortable in their practice by:

- **Accommodating all experience-levels** – in all our courses and live events, we cater to beginners as a baseline because they have everything to gain, whereas intermediate and advanced breathers have nothing to lose
- **Creating educational content** – we provide free resources on our blog for anyone interested in breathwork, regardless of their prior experience; we’re also available on email and social media channels to answer questions and offer advice
- **Accommodating all abilities** – we're transparent about our contraindications and always offer alternatives where possible
- **Introducing new practices** – we want to create ways of working with the breath for anyone and everyone, so we strive to constantly expand our offering

TARGET AUDIENCE

We serve a mindset, not a metric.

Our ideal customer is anyone, because our vision is to make breathwork available to everyone.

But the reality is, it takes a particular mindset to practise breathwork – whether for the first time, or as a trained facilitator. We can’t force people to be ready, and we’d never want to. So when we think about our target audience, there are certain characteristics that make people more receptive to our work.

Psychographics

Our target audience are…

- Actively curious
- Quietly courageous
- Seeking change and transformation
- Open to learning and new ideas
- Receptive to new perspectives
- Prepared to show up and do the work
- Committed to facing their own emotions, good and bad
- Ready to show leadership and take responsibility
- Equipped with a certain body awareness
- Motivated to be the change they want to see in the world
- Dreams of healing themselves and others
- Looking for meaning or purpose
- Longing for community and connection

Their challenges include…

- Standing up for themselves
- Self-expression
- Understanding their own conditioning and cycles
- Seeking community
- Craving validation
- Being fearful of judgement
- Looking for a sense of identity
- Low confidence and self-esteem

Buyer personas

When we're thinking about Alchemy of Breath's ideal customer, it can help to picture an actual person. That's why we've come up with these buyer personas, to represent the different types of people we serve (or want to serve).

Each time you create a new course, or write an email, or talk to a group of people in a session, think about *who* you're communicating with. Is it Mona, Barbs, Paul, or Jason? Or a combination of them all? What's the best way to speak to your audience to make sure they connect with your message?

Use what you know about these personas to show empathy and understanding – which might mean adapting your language, focusing on different benefits, or using a slightly different approach in the way you teach, as an example.

Having said that, we should take care not to be too literal in our assumptions or we risk alienating others we're trying to reach. Use with caution!

Mona: The Expert Innovator

Breathwork experience?

- Regular breathwork practitioner
- Understands day-to-day benefits of the practice
- May not be aware of how deep the benefits can go

Who are they?

- 30-60
- Working full-time
- Looking for a change in career direction – wondering ‘what’s next?’
- Heavily relied on by those around her
- Yearns to be listened to the way she listens to others
- Feels stuck in the motions of life
- Reflective about her past and what led her to now
- Can feel disconnected from herself and others

Customer need?

Benefit:

- Lifestyle change

Features:

- Community to belong to
- Journey of self-discovery

Pain words

Lack of clarity, low self-esteem, low energy, empty, struggling, closed, sensitive, feeling unseen, lacking confidence, emotional

Gain words

Control, clarity, security, connection with self, intimacy, trust, healing, direction, energy, ready for next step

Barbs: The Enlightened Early-Adopter

Breathwork experience?

- Regularly practices yoga, breathwork or other wellness practice
- Has at least tried breathwork
- Understands the general benefits

Who are they?

- 35-65
- Working full-time
- Has experienced some kind of emotional loss
- Has built up walls
- Tries to sort out problems alone, but feels lonely
- Is looking for further clarity about what's coming next
- Feels things are sometimes out of her control
- Will invest money in things she sees value in, but likes to know details before committing

Customer need?

Benefit:

- Find clarity

Features:

- Cost-effective
- Expands current practice
- Community to belong to

Pain words

Emotional, traumatic, guilt, shame, burnout, worries, lonely, vulnerable, pressured, self critical, sadness

Gain words

Security, independence, openness, purpose, growth, self discipline, focus, self discovery, compassion, connection

Paul: The Sceptical Businessperson

Breathwork experience?

- No experience with breathwork or any other healing modality

Who are they?

- 28-40
- Accomplishment- and ego-orientated
- Overstretched, overreaching, about to crash
- Insecure and seeks acknowledgement from the outside
- Will rise to a challenge, even when beyond his capability
- Possibly heading towards a mid-life crisis
- Excess energy, accelerating in the wrong direction

Customer need?

Benefit:

- Performing better with less stress

Features:

- Community to belong to

Pain words

Burnout, stress, worry, pressure, self-critical, underperforming, trauma

Gain words

Self-discipline, focus, performance, sleep, strength, solidarity, hero, leader, service, vulnerable, self-discovery, compassion, creative, breakthrough, independence

Jason: The Health-Conscious Athlete

Breathwork experience?

- One toe in the holistic/alternative healing world
- Might follow Wim Hoff, SOMA Breath, or Oxygen Advantage

Who are they?

- Late-30s to 45
- Strong interest in physical health, wellbeing and longevity
- Part of him is suffering, but remains unrecognised
- Wants to be who he is and not always trying to prove himself or put on a show
- Feels there's something more to life
- Accomplished, but beginning to realise it's not enough

Customer need?

Benefit:

- Achieving optimal health and wellbeing

Features:

- Community to belong to

Pain words

Illness, burnout, stress, worries

Gain words

Healthy, strong, happy, wellness, energy, sleep, physical performance, focus, determination, immunity, potential

TONE OF VOICE

Magical, inclusive & compelling.

Our tone of voice builds trust and recognition among existing and potential customers, conveying our individuality and strengthening our brand identity. It’s important it’s consistent across all our copy and communications.

MAGICAL

Charismatic. Inspiring. Exciting.

Alchemy of Breath is a visionary brand. We want to make our customers' dreams come true and change their lives for the better. We value magical moments and strive to make things exciting, to inspire people to break free from the ordinary and try new things.

Spark wonder

We want to excite people and inspire them to come on an adventure with us. So dial up the energy! Be bold and expressive. Find unique, creative ways to communicate that spark our audience's imagination and encourage beginner's mind.

Empower your reader

We want to make people feel anything is possible. That they have everything they need to transform their life. We use strong, uplifting language and lots of questions to encourage our audience to consider the answer for themselves – empowering them to find their own way, rather than deciding the answer for them.

Be optimistic

We are compassionate and gentle, but not feeble or full of woe. We're not overly enthusiastic, but we maintain an upbeat, optimistic tone.

Be wary of mysticism or mystery
Remember to think about which of our buyer personas you're talking to. Some of our audience are open to mysticism, but others are more skeptical or pragmatic and prefer to hear facts and logic. Some enjoy the excitement of mystery, but it may make others feel we're hiding something. It's important to meet our audience where they're at.

Stop short of fantastical
Don’t take liberties with people’s trust by exaggerating, being unrealistic, or over-promising – this will only make us appear dishonest.

Speak to the individual
Yes, we have a strong community. But we encourage every member to connect to their own magic. We avoid collective assumptions and encourage our customers to trust their own instincts.

Don’t idolise anyone
At Alchemy of Breath, we don’t believe in gurus. We can admire people, but take care not to put anyone on a pedestal.

Choose punctuation wisely
Energetic language doesn’t need loads of exclamation marks! That just makes us sound hyperactive! Or even insincere! Instead, mix up your sentence length to add excitement to your syntax. Make long and beautiful and flowing. Or short and snappy. (And don’t be afraid to break the ‘rules’.)

INCLUSIVE

Accessible. Approachable. Human.

Alchemy of Breath is for everyone. You don’t need to have a background in healing, or even believe in spirituality to be part of our community. We want to spread the word as far as possible and see breathwork become mainstream – which means making sure the language we use is as inclusive as possible.

Avoid specialist language
The last thing we want to do is intimidate or alienate anyone. That’s why we steer away from technical jargon or spiritual terms when we’re talking in spaces where we might be addressing an audience new to breathwork – such as on our website, on social media, and in emails – because we want everyone to relate to what we’re saying and feel they can get involved.

We’ve also introduced a glossary of niche terms, to inform and include anyone who wants to learn more. These are words we should use with caution when we’re talking to a broad, potentially novice audience. If we do use them, it’s always best to explain what we mean.

Explain, don’t patronise
We never assume people are experts (or even intermediates!) in breathwork – we always explain ourselves clearly and thoroughly. But we never, ever patronise or talk down to anyone, no matter how little they know about our practice.

Be a global citizen
Though we communicate in English, we’re proud to count people of all nationalities as part of our community. So we avoid slang and complex words that not everyone might understand.

Talk like a human
We are a loving, supportive community of real people with real stories. We talk like humans, not robots or sales reps – we never want to sound formal, disconnected or distant. If in doubt, read it out. Would you speak that way to a friend?

Be kind
Honor our responsibility to our community and remember we’re dealing with potentially vulnerable people, not just numbers. Encourage kindness in our community through leading by example.

Put yourself in their shoes
We strive to deeply connect with our audience and meet them where they're at. We put ourselves in their shoes, acknowledging and answering their potential questions, doubts and insecurities before they have to ask. That way, we nurture their confidence and trust.

Check your language
In order to create a safe and open environment where everyone feels welcome, we avoid using expressions or words that might exclude particular groups of people. Here are a few things to watch out for:

- ***Put people first*** – put a person ahead of their characteristics, e.g. "a man who is blind" rather than "a blind man" (although this comes down to individual preference, so it's best to ask)
- ***Be gender-inclusive*** – avoid terms like "guys" or "manpower," use "they" as a neutral pronoun, and defer to neutral role descriptors like "police officer" and "chairperson"
- ***Don't suggest victimhood*** – steer clear of phrases like "victim of" or "suffers from," along with euphemisms like "challenged" or "differently abled"
- ***Respect mental disabilities*** – only use terms like "bipolar" and "OCD" to refer to actual psychiatric disabilities, and avoid derogatory terms like "crazy" or "psycho"
- ***Be aware of racist undertones*** – avoid phrases where "black" denotes "bad," such as "blacklist" or "black sheep"

We're committed to listening to our community and are always open to feedback that makes the way we communicate more inclusive.

COMPELLING

Authoritative. Intelligent. Humble.

Alchemy of Breath has years of breathwork experience and expertise. We hold ourselves and our students to the highest professional standards. We want to prove to our audience we know what we're talking about and give them good reasons to choose to breathe with us over our competitors.

Be authoritative
We are experts in our field, so we communicate with confidence to make sure our audience knows that. We speak literally and logically, backing up our claims with insights and evidence.

Show what value we bring
We avoid speaking in riddles and we don't rely on readers to connect the dots. Instead, we put our audience's needs first and spell out what they'll get and why they should care, to prove we're worth their investment.

Stay humble
Remember: breathing is for everyone. This isn't about making ourselves look good, it's about helping people. We can speak with authority, without being arrogant or domineering. We never criticise our competitors, or talk down to others.

Keep it simple
Leonardo Da Vinci said, “Simplicity is the ultimate sophistication.” And Einstein said, "If you can't explain an idea simply, you don't understand it well enough." Follow their lead and your writing will be far more compelling for your reader.

Use fewer words if you can
Huge chunks of text not only intimidate and confuse, they can also give the impression we don’t know what we’re talking about. Respect our audience’s intelligence and attention span by writing concisely. And use plenty of paragraph breaks to give their eyes a break and increase focus.

Be open and honest
We nurture trust through transparency and don’t pretend to be something we’re not. For example, we’re proud to be a small team, not a giant corporation! We avoid seeming manipulative by giving readers the facts so they can decide for themselves

STYLE GUIDELINES

The practicalities of writing.

Alchemy of Breath uses US English. Here are a few things to look out for in your writing.

Spelling

- -ize or -yze *not* -ise or -yse – e.g. organize, recognize, analyze, paralyze
- -or *not* -our – e.g. color, flavor, honor, humor (except for ‘contour’, ‘velour’, ‘paramour’ and ‘troubadour’)
- -er *not* -re – e.g. center, kilometer, theater, caliber, fiber, saber and somber
- -ce vs -se. – in most instances use -se, e.g. defense and offense; however, US English uses 'advice’ as a noun and ‘advise’ as a verb, but does not distinguish between meanings for ‘practice’ and ‘license’ (spelled as seen)
- -e not -ae or -oe – e.g. amoeba, anaemia, anaesthesia, foetal, haemophilia, oesophagus, orthopaedic and paediatric
- Percent *not* per cent

Punctuation

- Use double quote marks for speech
- If quoting speech within speech, use single quote marks

Acronyms

- We don’t use full stops in acronyms, e.g. US, UK, GPBA
  - If the short version isn't generally familiar (or if you aren’t sure how well known it is), introduce the abbreviation in brackets after the full phrase the first time you use it, then use the short version from then on – e.g. Global Professional Breathwork Alliance (GPBA)

Numbers

- Write numbers from one to ten as words and from 11 upwards as figures
  - Same goes for first, second, third, and so on, up to tenth
  - But don't mix it up, e.g. 9–11
- Don’t use figures at the start of a sentence, e.g. Twelve days after we we begon the course...
- Put a comma in numbers over 1,000 (and every three zeros after that)
- Spell out million and billion

Times and dates

- Format dates like this: March 19th 2021
- Use the 12-hour clock with a colon and ‘am’ and ‘pm’ (without full stops) – e.g. 2:00 pm (add space between the number and the letters)
  - When using a time range, remember to use an en-dash (–), not a hyphen (-)